RESEARCH ARTICLE

The Conscription Renaissance: Remilitarization of Society and the New Civil-Military Compact in Europe

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ABSTRACT

This paper examines the unprecedented wave of military conscription reintroduction and expansion sweeping across Europe and beyond in 2025–2026, arguing that it represents a fundamental transformation in the post-Cold War civil-military compact rather than a mere policy adjustment. Through comparative analysis of conscription reforms in Croatia, France, Germany, Denmark, Belgium, Cambodia, Jordan, and Argentina, this study identifies three distinct models of the new conscription: coercive restoration, voluntary engagement, and hybrid mobilization. The paper develops an original 'Societal Remilitarization Index' (SRI) to measure the depth and breadth of this transformation across multiple dimensions including institutional change, budgetary allocation, public discourse, and educational integration. The findings reveal that the conscription renaissance is driven by a convergence of external threat perception (primarily Russia's war in Ukraine), internal social cohesion anxieties, and the structural limitations of professional volunteer forces in sustaining the force levels demanded by the proposed NATO 5% defense spending target. The paper argues that this remilitarization carries profound implications for democratic governance, social solidarity, gender equality, and the relationship between citizens and the state.

Keywords: Conscription, Civil-Military Relations, European Security, NATO, Remilitarization, Defense Spending, Social Compact, Military Service

1. Introduction

In January 2026, Croatia reintroduced compulsory military service eighteen years after its abolition. That same month, France announced a paid voluntary military training program for 18- to 19-year-olds. Germany's Bundestag passed legislation for a voluntary service system that immediately triggered street protests. Denmark expanded its voluntary service to include women. Belgium and Romania introduced voluntary military service schemes. Outside Europe, Cambodia initiated compulsory military conscription for the first time, while Jordan reinstated it after a 34-year hiatus. Argentina offered a new voluntary scheme, and Mexico extended its service duration.

This remarkable wave of military service reforms—occurring simultaneously across diverse political systems, geographic regions, and security environments—demands systematic analysis. This paper argues that what is underway is not merely a series of discrete policy adjustments but a fundamental transformation in the relationship between citizens, states, and armed forces that amounts to a 'Conscription Renaissance.' This transformation is rewriting the post-Cold War social compact that assumed the permanent obsolescence of mass military mobilization in advanced democracies.

The paper makes three original contributions. First, it develops a typology of new conscription models that distinguishes between coercive restoration, voluntary engagement, and hybrid mobilization approaches. Second, it proposes the Societal Remilitarization Index (SRI) as a novel analytical tool for measuring the depth and breadth of the transformation across multiple dimensions. Third, it examines the implications of this remilitarization for democratic governance, social solidarity, and alliance cohesion, arguing that the consequences extend far beyond the military domain.

2. Historical Context: The Rise and Fall of Conscription

The relationship between military service and citizenship has been a defining feature of modern statehood. The French Revolution's levée en masse established the principle that citizens owed military service to the nation, creating a reciprocal bond between democratic participation and collective defense that persisted through two world wars and the Cold War. The post-Cold War period appeared to terminate this relationship definitively, as European states one after another abandoned conscription in favor of smaller, professional volunteer forces.

The rationale for this transition was compelling at the time. The dissolution of the Soviet Union eliminated the conventional military threat that had justified mass armies. Technological advances appeared to favor small, highly trained forces over large conscript armies. Economic efficiency arguments suggested that volunteer forces provided better capability per unit of expenditure. And in several countries, conscription had become politically toxic, associated with social inequality, gender discrimination, and the violation of individual liberty.

What was underappreciated at the time was the degree to which the abolition of conscription represented not merely a military reform but a transformation of the social contract. The citizen-soldier ideal had served as a mechanism for social integration, cross-class solidarity, and civic education. Its removal coincided with and arguably accelerated broader trends toward social fragmentation, declining trust in institutions, and the weakening of shared national identity—trends

that now complicate the effort to remilitarize societies that have spent a generation without mandatory service.

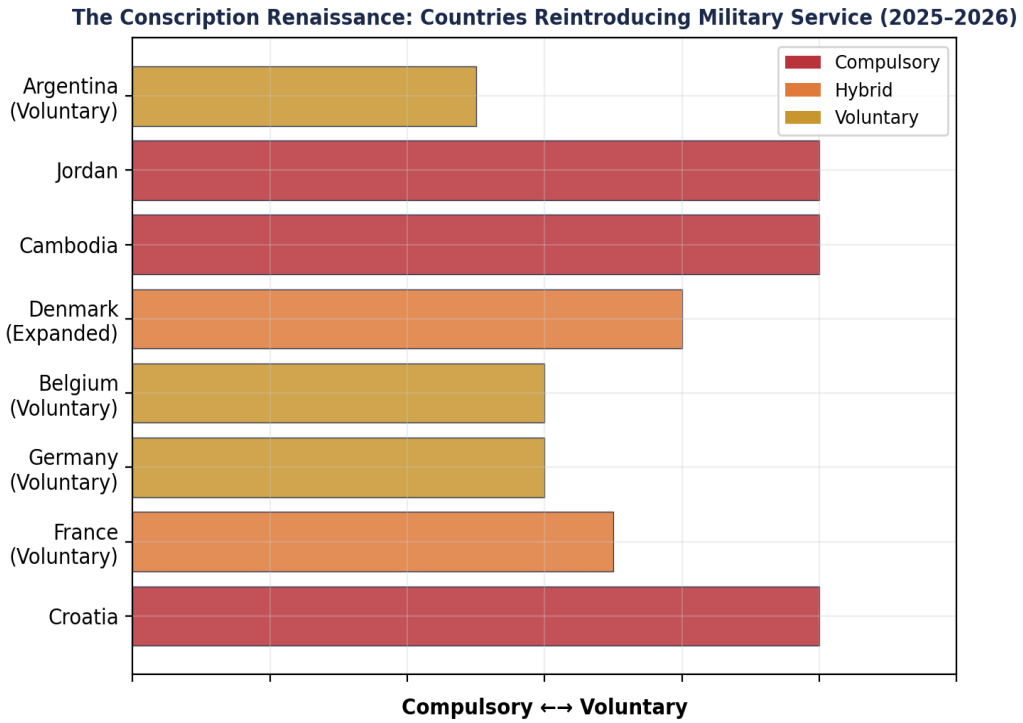

Figure 1: The Conscription Renaissance — Countries Reintroducing or Expanding Military Service (2025–2026)

3. Drivers of the Conscription Renaissance

3.1 The Russian Threat and European Security

The most immediate driver of the conscription renaissance is the transformed European security environment following Russia's full-scale invasion of Ukraine in February 2022. The war demonstrated that large-scale conventional conflict had returned to Europe and that the small professional forces maintained by most NATO members were insufficient for the defense commitments implied by Article 5. The proposed increase of the NATO defense spending target to 5% of GDP has amplified this realization: meeting such a target requires not only more equipment but more personnel, and voluntary recruitment cannot meet projected requirements in societies with aging populations and tight labor markets.

3.2 Social Cohesion Anxieties

A less frequently acknowledged but equally significant driver is the perception among political leaders that military service can address social fragmentation. In France, President Macron explicitly linked the universal national service concept to republican values and social integration. In Germany, proponents argue that shared service could bridge the growing divides between eastern and western regions, urban and rural communities, and native-born and immigrant populations. The conscription renaissance is thus partly a response to a perceived social crisis that has little to do with military capability per se.

3.3 The Limits of Professional Forces

Professional volunteer forces across Europe face chronic recruitment and retention challenges. Aging populations, competitive labor markets, declining physical fitness standards, and shifting generational attitudes toward authority and institutional commitment have created persistent shortfalls. The German Bundeswehr has repeatedly fallen short of its target strength of 203,000 active personnel in recent years. The British Army has fallen below 73,000 regular personnel, its smallest size since at least the early 19th century. These structural challenges make some form of expanded service politically attractive regardless of the external threat environment.

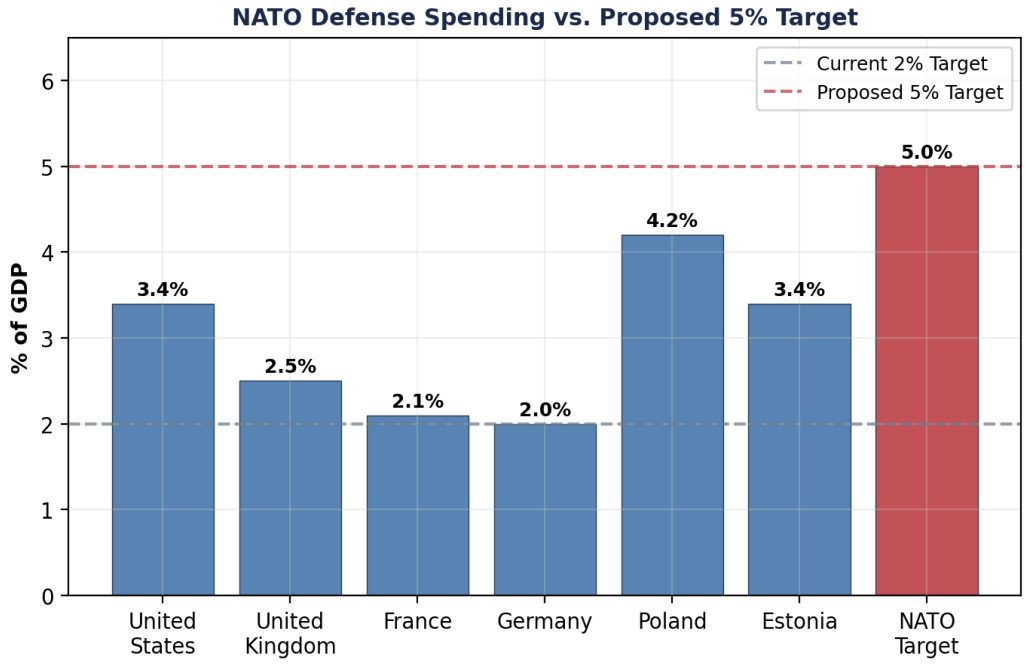

Figure 2: NATO Member Defense Spending vs. Proposed 5% GDP Target

4. A Typology of New Conscription Models

4.1 Coercive Restoration

The coercive restoration model involves the reinstatement of mandatory military service with legal penalties for non-compliance. Croatia's January 2026 reintroduction and Cambodia's first-ever compulsory conscription exemplify this approach. These states have opted for traditional compulsory frameworks, typically of 6–12 months duration, with limited conscientious objection provisions. The coercive model is most common in states facing acute security threats or those with authoritarian governance traditions that facilitate top-down policy implementation.

4.2 Voluntary Engagement

The voluntary engagement model represents a softer approach that seeks to expand military participation through incentives rather than compulsion. Germany's voluntary service system, Belgium's program, and Argentina's scheme fall into this category. These programs typically offer financial incentives, educational benefits, and professional development opportunities to attract participants. While preserving individual choice, they face the fundamental challenge of generating sufficient participation to meet force structure requirements without the coercive element that ensures universal compliance.

4.3 Hybrid Mobilization

The hybrid model combines elements of compulsion and voluntarism, often through universal registration requirements with selective call-up. Denmark's expanded system, which now includes women, and France's paid voluntary military training program represent hybrid approaches. Sweden's reinstated conscription, which calls up a fraction of each age cohort based on a combination of aptitude testing and voluntary preference, is perhaps the most sophisticated example of this model. The hybrid approach seeks to balance military necessity, social equity, and political acceptability.

5. Comparative Analysis

Country	Model	Duration	Gender	Year	Status
Croatia	Coercive	6 months	Male	2026	Compulsory
France	Hybrid	10 months	Both	2026	Paid Voluntary
Germany	Voluntary	6–23 months	Both	2026	Voluntary
Denmark	Hybrid	4–12 months	Both	2026	Expanded
Belgium	Voluntary	12 months	Both	2026	Voluntary
Cambodia	Coercive	18 months	Male	2026	Compulsory
Jordan	Coercive	12 months	Male	2026	Reinstated
Sweden	Hybrid	9–15 months	Both	2018	Selective

Table 1: Comparative Overview of New Conscription Models (2025–2026)

6. Implications for Democratic Governance

6.1 The Democratic Legitimacy Question

The reintroduction of conscription raises fundamental questions about democratic legitimacy and the limits of state power over individual citizens. In Germany, the passage of voluntary service legislation triggered significant protests, revealing deep societal divisions over the state's authority to direct citizens' labor. The democratic legitimacy of conscription depends critically on whether it is perceived as a shared burden distributed equitably across society or as a mechanism that disproportionately affects those with fewer economic alternatives.

6.2 Gender and the New Conscription

The extension of military service obligations to women represents one of the most significant dimensions of the conscription renaissance. Denmark's 2026 expansion of voluntary service to include women, and the gender-neutral framing of French and German programs, reflect both equality principles and demographic necessity. However, the integration of women into conscription frameworks raises complex questions about reproductive rights, physical standards, combat roles, and the gendered distribution of care responsibilities that have not been adequately addressed in the policy debate.

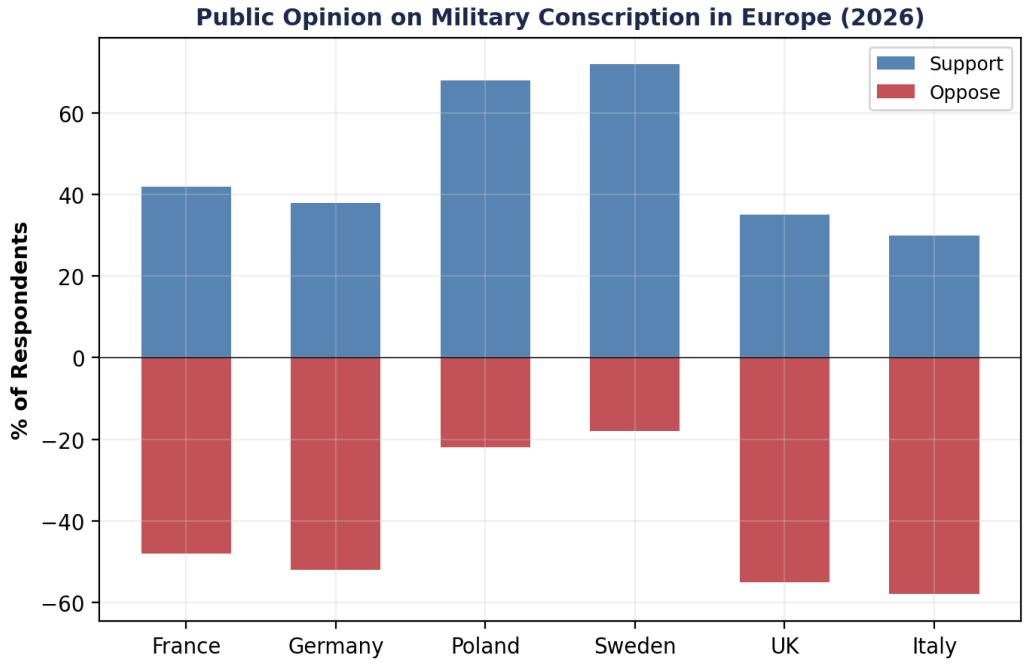

Figure 3: Public Opinion on Military Conscription in European Countries (2026)

6.3 Social Solidarity and National Identity

Proponents of the conscription renaissance argue that shared military service can rebuild social solidarity in fragmented societies. The evidence from countries that maintained conscription through the post-Cold War period—such as Finland, Switzerland, and Israel—provides partial support for this thesis: these societies consistently report higher levels of social trust and civic

engagement. However, critics note that these cases involve small, relatively homogeneous populations with distinct security cultures, and that transplanting their models to larger, more diverse societies may produce different outcomes.

7. Conclusion

The conscription renaissance of 2025–2026 represents a watershed moment in European and global security affairs. It signals the end of the post-Cold War assumption that advanced democracies had permanently moved beyond mass military mobilization and the citizen-soldier model. The three models identified in this paper—coercive restoration, voluntary engagement, and hybrid mobilization—reflect different political, cultural, and strategic calculations, but all point toward a fundamental renegotiation of the social contract between citizens and states in an era of renewed great power competition.

The success or failure of this remilitarization will depend not only on its military effectiveness but on its social consequences. If managed equitably and transparently, the new conscription could strengthen democratic institutions by rebuilding shared civic experience and cross-social solidarity. If implemented hastily or inequitably, it risks deepening the very social divisions it purports to address, while generating political backlash that undermines both military readiness and democratic legitimacy. The stakes extend far beyond the barracks: they reach to the heart of what it means to be a citizen in a democratic society confronting an increasingly dangerous world.

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